

Glossary

asteroid Giant rock, also called a minor planet or planetoid, that circles the Sun. There are hundreds of thousands in our solar system and more are being discovered all the time

astronaut Person who has been trained to travel inside a spacecraft

astronomy Branch of science that studies the places beyond the Earth such as stars, planets, comets, and galaxies

atmosphere Thin layer of gas surrounding the Earth for about 100 km (63 miles), which fades gradually into space beyond

comet Space snowball made of dust, rock, and ice that orbits the Sun. Comets develop a bright head and tail when near the Sun

dwarf planet Celestial body too small to be considered a planet, and orbits the Sun amongst other objects

galaxy Large system of stars, gas, dust, and empty space that rotates but is held together by gravity. The Earth and its solar system are part of a galaxy called the Milky Way

gas Freely moving atoms or particles without a definite shape

gravity Attraction between everything in the Universe. Gravity makes the Earth and the other planets in the solar system orbit the Sun, and the Moon rotate around the Earth

light year Distance light travels in one year

meteor Short-lived streak of light produced by a small piece of space rock burning up in the Earth's atmosphere

meteorite Piece of space rock that survives the journey through the Earth's atmosphere and lands on its surface

moon Natural satellite, or an object orbiting a planet. The Earth has one moon, though more than 170 orbit other solar system planets

black hole

Area with a gravitational pull so strong that it sucks in anything that comes too close. Scientists know black holes exist because of their effect on nearby stars

